

## MODULE 23 / 40

# Chipping Sparrow

*Spizella passerina*

## QUICK STATS

|          |                                  |
|----------|----------------------------------|
| Length   | 4.7 – 5.9 in (12 – 15 cm)        |
| Wingspan | 8.3 in (21 cm)                   |
| Weight   | 0.4 – 0.6 oz (11 – 16 g)         |
| Lifespan | Up to 9 years (avg. 2–3 in wild) |

## PRESENTATION

The Chipping Sparrow is one of the most familiar and confiding small sparrows in North America — a trim, clean-looking bird whose bright rufous cap, bold white eyebrow, and unstreaked gray breast make it one of the easiest sparrows to identify in breeding plumage. It is a common inhabitant of suburban gardens, parks, and open woodlands, often nesting close to human activity and readily visiting feeders scattered with white millet. Its song — a long, mechanical trill on a single pitch — is one of the most familiar sounds of North American spring and summer, frequently confused with the trill of an insect. It is sometimes called the "hair bird" for its habit of lining its nest with animal hair.

## HABITAT & RANGE

The Chipping Sparrow breeds across most of North America, from the Yukon and Northwest Territories east to Newfoundland and south through virtually the entire United States into Mexico and Central America. It inhabits open and semi-open environments with scattered trees: suburban gardens, parks, orchards, forest edges, open pine woodlands, and grassy areas with shrubs. It shows a particular affinity for lawns edged with conifers. Northern populations migrate south in winter, when the rufous cap is replaced by a duller, streaked brown crown.

## DIET & FEEDING

- White millet — the top feeder food, eagerly taken from the ground
- Black-oil sunflower chips and cracked corn
- Wild grass seeds — the dominant natural food
- Weed seeds: crabgrass, chickweed, smartweed
- Insects and spiders — essential during breeding season
- Primarily forages on the ground beneath feeders and shrubs

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Chipping Sparrows are tame and approachable birds, often allowing close observation as they forage quietly on lawns and garden paths. During the breeding season males are territorial, singing persistently from a tree or shrub perch. Outside the breeding season they become gregarious, forming loose flocks with other sparrows and juncos. They forage almost exclusively on the ground, moving with quick, darting hops and picking up seeds with precise bill movements. Their small size and unobtrusive manner mean they are often overlooked despite being remarkably common in suburban areas.

NESTING & BREEDING

Chipping Sparrows build compact, neatly woven cup nests of grasses and rootlets, almost always lined with fine animal hair — deer hair, horse hair, or even human hair collected near stables and farms. Nests are placed in shrubs or small conifers, typically 3–10 feet above the ground. The female lays 3–5 pale blue eggs with dark spots and incubates them alone for 11–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 9–12 days. Pairs raise 2 broods per season. They are frequent cowbird hosts.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Chipping Sparrow's song is a prolonged, rapid, mechanical trill on a single pitch — "chrrrrrrrrrrr" — lasting 3–4 seconds and remarkably insect-like in quality. It is one of the commonest sounds of suburban spring mornings. The call is a sharp, high "tsip" — thin and easily overlooked. Males sing persistently from dawn to mid-morning throughout the breeding season.

CONSERVATION STATUS

|                |               |                   |           |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|-----------|
| IUCN Red List: | Least Concern | Population trend: | Declining |
|----------------|---------------|-------------------|-----------|

The Chipping Sparrow population is estimated at 230 million individuals but has declined by roughly 27% since 1970. The primary threats are brood parasitism by Brown-headed Cowbirds, habitat loss through suburban development eliminating open grassy areas with scattered trees, and pesticide use reducing insect availability during the breeding season.

FEEDER TIPS

- Scatter white millet on the ground or a low platform feeder
- Chipping Sparrows forage directly beneath tube feeders — no platform needed
- They are tame and often approach within a few feet of a patient observer
- Leave short-mown lawn areas near feeders — they love to forage on grass
- A small birdbath on or near the ground is strongly attractive to them

COLORING GUIDE

| ZONE              | RECOMMENDED COLOR            |
|-------------------|------------------------------|
| Crown (breeding)  | Bright rufous chestnut       |
| White supercilium | Bold white eyebrow stripe    |
| Black eye line    | Sharp black line through eye |
| Back & wings      | Brown, streaked dark         |
| Face & underparts | Clean pale gray — unstreaked |
| Bill              | Short, conical, dark gray    |

## COLOR ME!

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